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THE FIRST FEW WEEKS of 1986 were a blur of tragedy and international crisis. There was the *Challenger* disaster, the fall of Ferdinand Marcos in the Philippines, a new clash with Japan over its restrictions on American imports, new efforts by Congress to starve the Contras, and continuing problems in the Middle East. On January 7, I wrote in the diary: “After quite a session, I finally came down on the side of an executive order bringing Americans and American business home from Libya and canceling relations—trade, etc., with them. At the same time we beef up the Sixth Fleet in the Mediterranean Sea. If Mr. Qaddafi decides not to push another terrorist act, okay, we’ve been successful with our implied threat. If on the other hand he takes this for weakness and does loose another one, we will have targets in mind and instantly respond with a h—1 of a punch. At tonight’s press conference, I announce the executive order.”

As I’ve mentioned before, with all the prominence that the Iran-Contra affair has since received, it might seem that all we were thinking about at the White House during that period was the Iran initiative. But it was only one of many, many things that were occupying us at the time. Not only were there major items of foreign policy such as arms control and problems in Nicaragua and the Philippines and visits with various heads of state, but there was a full plate of domestic issues as well, notably the battle to reform taxes and cut the budget deficit, and, of course, the *Challenger* tragedy. On any given day, I was sent dozens of documents to read, and saw an average of eighty people. I set the policy, but I turned over the day-to-day details to the